



Human Sustainability Winter Quarter, 2026

Professor

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Course Overview

Human sustainability is the degree to which an employee can maintain a given level of performance over an indefinite period of time. Poor human sustainability ends in burnout, turnover, illness, or even death. Organizations should value human sustainability from a values-based perspective, in that it is an ethically-laden issue (you should care about your people!). However, above and beyond any moral reasons for valuing human sustainability, a utilitarian perspective highlights how human capital is a source of competitive advantage for a firm. So preserving the quality of that human capital is important for the success of a firm. This class focuses on understanding human sustainability, what undermines human sustainability, and how to improve human sustainability. We will consider both how to manage your own human sustainability, as well as how leaders can improve the human sustainability of their organizations.

Course Objectives

- Teach skills of good human sustainability
- Help you see the importance of human sustainability
- Show how managing for human sustainability is a source of competitive advantage

Expectations and Course Plan

I run a highly participative course, with many discussions and exercises. While I will endeavor to make these sessions engaging and interesting, it is your responsibility to come to class prepared and motivated to learn.

Here are the components that will comprise your grade for the course:

A. *In Class Reflections* (25%). In many of our sessions, I will ask you to write down three things you learned from class that day, 3 things you hope to remember 10 years from now, or some combination of those two categories. This will be a short exercise designed to help solidify some of the content for the session in your long term memory. This can only be completed in class.

B. *Group Project (35%)*. In this project, you will discuss and address an issue of human sustainability that one of you has observed in a workplace. You will start with a description of the issue, and how that issue ties into the content of this course. Next, you will design a solution to this issue. Finally, you will delineate a plan for selling the solution to higher leadership. You will share your written document with the class.

C. *Group Project Peer Evaluations (5%)*. You will evaluate the group projects of all of the other groups. I will send you a brief online assessment form. This will include giving a score based on a 100 point scale. Your mean and median evaluation must be no higher than 88 out of 100. This will help you to process the group projects more deeply, as well as de-bias my grading of the group projects.

D. *Conceptual Integration Essay (35%)*. This is an open-book, open-note test you do asynchronously. Once you start the test, you will have 2 hours to complete it. I will present you with a scenario to solve. You will first ask an AI to solve it. Then you will indicate what class content the AI included that was directly on-target. Then you will discuss what especially relevant class content the AI did not use.

Grading

In business, employees who do what is expected of them are generally considered to be average performers. Those who do what is expected of them but do it excellently are good performers. But those who go above and beyond what is expected of them and do it excellently are stars. *Please don't expect star grades for what is average or even good work.*

Grades will be assigned according to the following schedule:

% Grade	Course grade
95% and above	4.0
94-94.99%	3.9
93-93.99%	3.8
92-92.99%	3.7
91-91.99%	3.6
90-90.99%	3.5
87-89.99%	3.4
86-86.99%	3.3
85-85.99%	3.2
84-84.99%	3.1
83-83.99%	3.0
82-82.99%	2.9
81-81.99%	2.8
80-80.99%	2.7
79-79.99	2.6
78-78.99	2.5
77-77.99	2.4
76-76.99	2.3

% Grade	Course grade
75-75.99	2.2
74-74.99	2.1
73-73.99	2.0
72-72.99	1.9
71-71.99	1.8
70-70.99	1.7

Class Attendance

Class attendance with your scheduled section is critical to participation in the learning experience. In accord with Foster policy, attendance and is required aside from circumstances related to (1) illness or (2) unavoidable conflict with a job or internship interview that cannot be rescheduled. Regardless of the rationale for missing a class meeting, please note that you are responsible for the learning experience that takes place in your absence; please work within your core team to address any material you may have missed, and please contact me afterward should you have specific questions about course content.

Student Professionalism in Class

Each student is expected to be on time to and prepared for each class meeting as well as fully engaged in class content throughout the class meeting. Please refrain from engaging in any activities other that might distract your classmates. This includes coming to class late, talking on your cell phone, allowing your cell phone to ring, snoring, having drunken brawls, creating a bonfire out of the chairs, actively plotting to overthrow me as the professor, changing into the Incredible Hulk, and so on.

The Honor Code

I employ the principles and procedures espoused by the Foster School of Business Honor System to maintain academic integrity in the course. The Honor Code of the Foster School expressly prohibits cheating, attempted cheating, plagiarism, and lying to administration or faculty as it pertains to academic work. Suspected violations of the Honor Code will be handled by referral of the matter to the Foster MBA Honor Council.

I expect that you will complete all deliverables required in the course in accordance with the principles of the Honor Code and submit them by the due dates assigned. If you have any uncertainty about how the Honor Code applies to a specific deliverable in the course, please ask before taking action; when it is not possible to ask before acting, please err on the side of conservatism.

Special Needs

If you have special needs due to a physical, emotional, or learning disability, contact me immediately. I will accommodate students' special needs to the best of my ability, but please notify me in advance. Students with disabilities should contact Disabled Student Services to develop reasonable accommodations. For an appointment with a counselor, call 543-8924 (voice) or 543-8925 (TTY), or e-mail uwdss@u.washington.edu.

Course Schedule

This schedule is tentative. Because the amount of time required to cover each topic tends to vary, topics may be changed or omitted depending on our progress throughout the quarter.

For each topic, I will typically use multiple means to convey the material. Preparation for each class will involve reading an article written for practitioners but generally grounded in the research literature.

Date	Topic	Preparation materials (complete before the class session, unless otherwise specified)
	Session 1: Introduction to Human Sustainability	Read before class: HBR – Could We Manage Not to Damage People’s Health? BBC Article - “Amazon apologises for wrongly denying drivers need to urinate in bottles” HBR Case – Amazon as an Employer In class video case: Merger Marathon
	Session 2: Work Demands, Stress, and Burnout	Read before class: HBR article - Employee Burnout Is a Problem with the Company, Not the Person HBR article – The Emotional Labor of Being a Leader HBR case – Goldman Sachs
	Session 3: Work Family Conflict	Read before class: HBR - The Surprising Benefits of Work/Life Support HBR – The Dangers of Mandatory Fun HBR case – Kathryn McNeil
	Session 4: Sleep and Shift Work	Read before class: HBR – Sleep Well Lead Better
	Session 5: Breaks from Work	Read before class: HBR - Making Time Off Predictable HBR - Research: The Transformative Power of Sabbaticals
	Session 6: Meaningful Work and Job Crafting	Read before class: HBR – Turn the Job You Have Into the Job You Want HBR Case – Job Crafting at Burt’s Bees
	Session 7: Building Resilience and Self-Compassion	Read before class: HBR – Be Kind to Yourself Today HBR – How to Bounce Back from Adversity HBR Case – Stress in the Workplace: Mental Health Conversations – The Boss
	Session 8: Mentorship and Volunteering	Read before class: HBR – What the Best Mentors Do HBR – Volunteer Programs that Employees Can Get Excited About HBR Case - Glass-Shattering Leaders: Michele Hooper

Date	Topic	Preparation materials (complete before the class session, unless otherwise specified)
	Session 9: Guest Speaker	
	Session 10: Looking Forward	Read before class: HBR – How Will You Measure Your Life? HBR Simulation – Crafting Your Life Simulation In class: Video case – Managing Growth

Appendix A: Group Project

Design a Nudge

You will find a problem that needs to be fixed in a workplace. This could be your former workplace, or it could be the workplace of a friend or family member. But it needs to be a real problem (as opposed to a fictional exercise).

Your task will be to design a nudge to fix that problem. Use the ideas from our class on nudges in generating your nudge. You may also find it useful to read Milkman et al. (2011) as well as the HBR article from your coursepack titled "A Practitioner's Guide to Nudging". And for even more background reading, you may find it helpful to read Nudge: Improving Decisions about Health, Wealth, and Happiness by Richard H. Thaler and Cass R. Sunstein.

Note that an effective nudge addresses a concrete problem, and does so in a relatively subtle manner. Try not to be too heavy-handed in your nudge. If you are not sure if you are being too heavy-handed, check with me. In creating your plan for a nudge, generate a way to see if it worked. Ideally this would involve data.

You will write up a report about your nudge. The format for the report should look roughly like this (double spaced, 1 inch margins, 12 point font):

1. Description of the problem. May include description of previous attempts to solve the problem, and why you think those attempts failed (1.5-3 pages).
2. Description of your nudge. This should include a rationale for why you think it would work, how you would implement it, and your plan for determining how well it worked (4-8 pages).
3. Recommendation for ways to adjust the nudge if it does not work (~1 page).

To go with your written document, your group will also record a 5 minute video (4-7 minutes). This is how you will share your nudge with the rest of the class. Everyone will watch all of these videos and then provide evaluations which I will take into account when grading the nudges. I am flexible on the details of the presentation, as long as you get across the main ideas of your nudge.

Here is my most useful advice for the nudge project: Create 1 single nudge which will provide 1 single solution to the 1 single problem. Stay focused. Don't aim to solve a bundle of problems. Don't provide a bundle of solutions. Keep it simple.

Milkman, K. L., Beshears, J., Choi, J. J., Laibson, D., & Madrian, B. C. (2011). Using implementation intentions prompts to enhance influenza vaccination rates. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America*, 108, 10415-10420.